Srila Bhakti Pramoda Puri Goswami Maharaj

Srila Bhakti Pramoda Puri Goswami Maharaj · @bhakti-pramoda-puri

A Companion of Srila Bhaktisiddhanta

Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati gathered great devotees around him, and one of the biographies compares that circle to the associates of Sri Chaitanya in the sixteenth century. One of them was Srila Bhakti Pramoda Puri Goswami Maharaj. His life is inseparable from the Gaudiya Math: he had no aim but to please his guru and Mahaprabhu.

Appearance and Youth

According to one biography, he appeared on 8 October 1898 at Ganganandapur, a village of the Jessore district (now in Bangladesh)[1]. His father was Tarini Charan Chakravarti, his mother Srimati Ram Rangini Devi, and his worldly name was Pramod Bhushan Chakravarti.

While still a boy he met the one who first showed him the way — his vartma-pradarshaka-guru, Srila Bhakti Ratna Thakura, a godbrother and shiksha-disciple of Srila Bhaktivinoda Thakura. Through him he came to know Srila Bhaktivinoda's journal "Sajjana-toshani", and then the "Sri Chaitanya-charitamrita", the "Sri Chaitanya-bhagavata" and the "Srimad-Bhagavatam"; from him, too, he first heard of his future guru — Srila Bhaktisiddhanta.

At the Feet of Srila Bhaktisiddhanta

He was still a university student when in 1915 he first came to Srila Bhaktisiddhanta at Yogapitha in Mayapur — on the day after the departure of Srila Gaurakishora Dasa Babaji. As he bowed before him for the first time, he recognised his guru in his heart, and later he often told of that meeting. On Janmashtami 1923 Srila Bhaktisiddhanta gave him harinama and mantra-diksha and the name Pranavananda Brahmachari.

For thirteen years he stayed near his guru and took down his lectures and talks; most of Srila Bhaktisiddhanta's words that have come down to us are transcripts of his notes. At his guru's instruction he wrote articles for the journal "Gaudiya", and for seven years was its proofreader and one of its chief editors. In 1926 he was entrusted with the "Dainika Nadiya Prakasha", then the only Vaishnava daily anywhere in the world; for two years he ran it, printing his guru's daily talks and the articles of other writers.

Srila Bhaktisiddhanta gave him the titles "maha-mahopadeshaka", great teacher, and "pratna-vidyalankara", guardian of the ancient scriptural wisdom, and said of him: he loves his guru, and his life and his words are one. The key to success in bhakti is to listen attentively to the guru; "lend me your ears", Srila Bhaktisiddhanta would ask, and Pranavananda followed this in everything. He ascribed all his success to his guru's mercy, and one disciple said of him that he set forth the whole siddhanta of Srila Bhaktisiddhanta without words.

After His Guru's Departure

When Srila Bhaktisiddhanta left this world[2], he continued preaching through the "Gaudiya" — first from the Bagbazar Gaudiya Math, then from the Sri Chaitanya Math in Mayapur. In 1942 his guru appeared to him in a dream, gave him the sannyasa mantra and told him to accept renunciation. In August 1946, at Champahati, he took tridandi-sannyasa from his godbrother Srila Bhakti Gaurava Vaikhanasa Maharaj, and then travelled across India with Srila Bhakti Hridaya Bon and Srila Bhakti

Dayita Madhava.

At the request of his godbrother Bhakti Vilasa Tirtha he was for seven years the chief pujari of the Yogapitha temple, the birthplace of Sri Chaitanya. In the 1950s he chose solitary worship and settled in a humble hut on the bank of the Ganges at Ambika-Kalna. The Maharaja of Burdwan, moved by his austerity, gave him the ancient temple of Ananta-Vasudeva in Kalna on Radhashtami 1958.

In 1964 Srila Bhakti Dayita Madhava asked him to lead the editors of the journal "Sri Chaitanya Vani", and for thirty-three years he served as chairman of its editorial board.

Sri Gopinath Gaudiya Math

In 1989, in his ninety-first year, he founded the Sri Gopinath Gaudiya Math at Ishodyan in Mayapur — for the service of Sri Sri Gaura-Gadadhara, Jagannatha, Radha-Gopinatha and Lakshmi-Nrisimha; his temples in Puri, Vrindavan, Kolkata and Medinipur followed. In 1995 he was elected president of the World Vaishnava Association. For his delicacy and precision in worship he was often asked to lead Deity installations and the ceremonies of the Gaudiya Math; it was he who performed the samadhi rite of Srila Bhakti Dayita Madhava on 27 February 1979.

Word and Pen

Steeped in the scriptures, he became a keeper of the treasure handed down from Sri Chaitanya through the line of acharyas, and one of the most fruitful writers and teachers among the Gaudiya Vaishnavas; at his guru's word he edited, wrote, published and helped to spread countless spiritual publications. For more than sixty years he wrote on Vaishnava philosophy and theology — hundreds of poems, essays, stories, diary pages, editorials and letters.

In his foreword to the Sri Chaitanya Gaudiya Math edition of the "Sri Chaitanya-charitamrita" he writes about Krishnadasa Kaviraja. Srila Vrindavana Dasa Thakura, absorbed in Nityananda's pastimes, did not unfold much of what he himself had listed at the start of his book, and the devotees of Vrindavan asked Krishnadasa to describe those pastimes. He went to Sri Madana-Mohana to ask leave, and before all the leading Vaishnavas of Vrindavan a garland slipped from the Deity; the pujari placed it on Krishnadasa's chest, and he, taking this as the Lord's will, began to write. Hence his words: "Having charged me with writing this book, Sri Madana-Gopala Himself dictates it to me, and I merely write after Him like a parrot" (Sri Chaitanya-charitamrita, Adi, 8.78). There, too, he retells a tradition about Vishvanatha Chakravarti. Vishvanatha could not understand why Kaviraja's kama-gayatri has twenty-four and a half syllables, and vowed to die at Radha-kunda; but Srimati Radhika told him in a dream that Krishnadasa is Her friend and writes correctly: according to the "Varnagama-bhasvata", the syllable "ya" before "vi" counts as a half.

In the collection "Sri Sarasvati-jayashri", published by the Bagbazar Gaudiya Math in 1948, appeared his article on the works of the vaishnava-sarvabhauma Srila Jagannatha Dasa Babaji. Of Srila Sridhar Maharaj's "Gayatri-nigudhartha" he wrote that this explanation of the gayatri as centred on Srimati Radharani had dawned upon its author by the mercy of Srila Bhaktisiddhanta, and that it is the best path to Krishna's mercy.

He was shiksha-guru and editor to Srila Bhakti Ballabha Tirtha Maharaj when the latter prepared the English edition of his biographies of the Lord's associates: he inspired him, edited the text and here and there added new information; the book is dedicated to him as well. In his foreword, dated 9 September 1992, he recalls that Srila Bhaktisiddhanta founded the Sri Chaitanya Math in Mayapur, and Srila Bhakti Dayita Madhava the Sri Chaitanya Gaudiya Math, leaving Bhakti Ballabha Tirtha as his successor; he praises the author, who even at seventy[3] edits a journal, writes books and manages the

maths, and especially thanks his dear Bhakti Varidhi Parivrajaka Maharaj, who printed the Bengali edition. The lives of devotees soften the heart, he writes, and the Lord's mercy comes in the wake of the Vaishnavas' mercy; so it is good to read them on the appearance and departure days of the associates.

He supports his thought with words from the "Sri Chaitanya-charitamrita", the "Sri Chaitanya-bhagavata" and the "Srimad-Bhagavatam", and with songs of Srila Bhaktivinoda and Srila Narottama Dasa Thakura: the Lord says that the honour shown to His devotee pleases Him more than honour shown to Himself, and that the acharya is to be known as He Himself: "Know the acharya to be Me" (Srimad-Bhagavatam, 11.17.27). Gaura is Krishna Himself, come in the Kali age after the Dvapara; in the Navadvipa pastimes sweetness is subordinate to generosity, and these qualities of Gaura are present in all His associates. Whoever reads their lives again and again is cleansed of envy and enmity and can, as the Lord taught by His own example, carry His message to every land.

Srila Bhaktisiddhanta called the printing press the "brihat-mridanga", the great drum: books and journals make preaching firm and far-reaching. Therefore, he writes, Parivrajaka Maharaj and Bhakti Ballabha Tirtha, in printing books, earn the love of their gurus and of all pure devotees. He prays that the author may live many more years, thanks all who helped with money and labour, asks pardon for any misprints left, and signs himself "begging for dust from the feet of pure devotees, a servant of the servants of the Vaishnavas". A passage of this foreword also appears on the cover of the English edition, signed "Swami B. P. Puri, Founder-Acharya of the Sri Gopinath Gaudiya Math".

Godbrothers and Senior Vaishnavas

He regarded Srila Sridhar Maharaj as his shiksha-guru. His close companions throughout life were Srila B. R. Sridhar Maharaj, Bhakti Prajnana Keshava and Akinchana Krishnadasa Babaji; he was known for his love for his godbrothers and his gift for glorifying them. Srila Bhakti Dayita Madhava, in one of his lectures, recalls his stories about Srila Gaurakishora Dasa Babaji. Srila Bhakti Ballabha Tirtha received his blessings and association and, from 1997, at his request, travelled the world preaching.

He had seen Vamshidasa Babaji in person and told stories about him. Once, at night, a thief carried off the utensils from Babaji's hut, and in the morning a cow ate the fruit set aside for the Deities; Babaji only laughed and clapped his hands: one thief gives, another takes away. Babaji did not let anyone touch his feet, but on the day after Phalguna Purnima, in ecstasy, he allowed it — and so he received the dust of his feet, and another time his prasad remnants. When someone sang Srila Bhaktivinoda's song "tyajiya shayana-sukha…", Babaji remarked that it opens only to one who has opened oneself; and when someone sang an invented "mantra" contrary to siddhanta, he said: "That name has no place here."

A certain man kept begging Babaji for mercy; one day Babaji took off his kaupina and held it out to him: "Is it my mercy you want? Take it, then", and the man took fright. So too, Puri Maharaj would say, we ask the Vaishnavas for mercy but are not ready to receive it. His aged godbrother Gokula Dasa Babaji, who came from a place near Babaji's home, often visited him, and the two would talk joyfully of Krishna in the Mymensingh dialect.

His Nature

He rested little: even in old age he wrote at night and chanted the Holy Name, and his servants always found him awake in the morning. A knower of the scriptures, he also looked after the printing press and sang kirtan beautifully. Humble and simple, he thought little of himself and made everyone feel needed and valued. People of many countries and walks of life found in him a guide and refuge on the spiritual path; he stood firm for pure Vaishnavism and explained the path of sharanagati, surrender to the Lord.

Departure

Before his departure he named his close disciple Sripad Bhakti Bibudha Bodhayan Maharaj to succeed him as president-acharya of the Sri Gopinath Gaudiya Math. According to the biography, Srila Bhakti Pramoda Puri Goswami Maharaj departed in the predawn hours of Narayana Chaturdashi, the day before Rasa Purnima, on 21 October 1999[4]. His sacred body was brought from Jagannatha Puri to the Gopinath Gaudiya Math at Ishodyan and laid in samadhi.

The biographer hopes that, once his words are translated, the world beyond Bengal and India too will discover the spirit of genuine Vaishnava religion, which he never tired of giving to others.

1. Our calendar (Sri Chaitanya Saraswat Math) does not list his appearance and departure days; the dates follow one biography.

2. The biography gives the year of Srila Bhaktisiddhanta's departure as 1937 in this chapter and as 1936 in another.

3. According to the same biography the author was born in 1924, so in 1992 he was sixty-eight.

4. The date and the tithi in the biography do not agree: by calculation, the full moon (Sharadiya Rasa) fell in 1999 on 24 October and shukla chaturdashi on 23 October, while at dawn on 21 October it was shukla ekadashi. Our calendar does not list his days; the biography gives no way to tell which indication is right.